

Japan Tech Conglomerates

Hardware above software still

Equities

Japan

Technology

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AI demand structure is unchanged

The expansion of coding AI has led to a sharp increase in demand for tokens and AI inference, and the fundamentals of AI data centre-related businesses are likely to remain robust. We believe growth in AI-related hardware demand is likely to continue, including for semiconductors, semiconductor manufacturing equipment, electric power, and high-performance packaging. However, the performance of coding AI is advancing not only through Anthropic Mythos but also via multiple product launches and improvements from OpenAI's Squad and China's Kimi, among others. Concerns about software-related businesses, including the "death of SaaS" narrative, are likely to persist. In the domestic IT services market, the greatest risk factor appears to be the shift by customers toward in-house development.

Among tech conglomerates, focus on SoftBank and SONY

We think growth in SoftBank's share price is likely to be driven by ARM due to capturing AI inference demand and the growing business value of OpenAI, due to accelerated monetisation from stronger coding AI. SONY has managed to offset the negative impact of DRAM price hikes, which was the most concerning issue before the full-year results announcement, through price increases. Furthermore, the share price is currently at a low level that, in our view, excessively reflects concerns about content value erosion due to AI. Panasonic's share price mostly reflects positive factors such as data centre BBUs and structural reform effects, pushing it down in terms of preference. At Fujitsu, a profit decline for hardware is likely hard to avoid in Q1, and we believe the outlook will remain challenging for a while.

Among semiconductor-related companies, focus on Tokyo Electron and Renesas

Tokyo Electron's price hike was one development not anticipated in this results season. Following this, market share and profit margins seem likely to expand going forward. At Renesas, sales appear likely to continue growing qoq in April-June as well, which would mark a sixth straight quarter of sales growth and reconfirm an upcycle. Overseas competitors have implemented further price hikes, following those in March-April. We expect Renesas to also see profit margin improvement. While Advantest and Disco are seeing solid trends amid tailwinds from AI demand, we believe their multiples are excessively high, leaving little appeal in their share prices at present.

Figure 1: Investment recommendations

Rating	Preference	Tech Conglomerates	SPE
Buy	High	SoftBank (9984) 	Tokyo Electron (8035)
		SONY (6758)	
		Hitachi (6501)	Renesas (6723)
		Panasonic (6752) 	NEC (6701)
Neutral		Mitsubishi Elec (6503) 	Advantest (6857)
			Disco (6146)
			SCREEN (7735)
		Fujitsu (6702)	Lasertec (6920)
Sell	Low	Sharp (6753)	

Source: UBS

Valuation Method and Risk Statement

Our valuation places equal emphasis on EV/EBITDA and PER. Risks include 1) changes in macroeconomic conditions, 2) the semiconductor and SPE cycle, which is highly sensitive to the economy, and 3) the clarification of core businesses.

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Sell	FSR is > 6% below the MRA.	6%	21%

Source: UBS. Rating allocations are as of 31 March 2026.

1:Percentage of companies under coverage globally within the 12-month rating category.

2:Percentage of companies within the 12-month rating category for which investment banking (IB) services were provided within the past 12 months.

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Company Name	Reuters	12-month rating	Price	Price date
Advantest ²⁸	6857.T	Neutral	¥28,615	14 May 2026
Disco ²⁸	6146.T	Neutral	¥70,000	14 May 2026
Fujitsu ^{4,28,18}	6702.T	Neutral	¥3,240	14 May 2026
Hitachi ²⁸	6501.T	Buy	¥4,671	14 May 2026
Lasertec Corporation ²⁸	6920.T	Neutral	¥40,560	14 May 2026
Mitsubishi Electric ²⁸	6503.T	Neutral	¥6,436	14 May 2026
NEC Corporation ^{12,28}	6701.T	Buy	¥4,049	14 May 2026
Panasonic ²⁸	6752.T	Buy	¥3,377	14 May 2026
Renesas Electronics ²⁸	6723.T	Buy	¥3,854	14 May 2026
SCREEN Holdings Co., Ltd. ^{5,28,18}	7735.T	Neutral	¥12,205	14 May 2026
Sharp	6753.T	Sell	¥572	14 May 2026
SoftBank Group ^{28,7}	9984.T	Buy	¥5,770	14 May 2026
Sony Group ^{16,28,7}	6758.T	Buy	¥3,444	14 May 2026
Tokyo Electron ²⁸	8035.T	Buy	¥51,200	14 May 2026

Source: UBS Global Research; LSEG Eikon. All prices as of local market close. Ratings in this table are the most current published ratings prior to this report. They may be more recent than the stock pricing date.

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